around with the machinery itself.

My partner in this task—the only other person responsible for the nocturnal functioning of the CIA's entire server architecture—was a guy I'm going to call Frank. He was our team's great outlier and an exceptional personality in every sense. Besides having a political consciousness (libertarian to the point of stockpiling Krugerrands) and an abiding interest in subjects outside of tech (he read vintage mysteries and thrillers in paperback), he was a fifty-something been-there-done-that ex-navy radio operator who'd managed to graduate from the call center's ranks thanks to being a contractor.

I have to say, when I first met Frank, I thought: *Imagine if my entire life were like the nights I spent at CASL.* Because, to put it frankly, Frank did hardly any work at all. At least, that was the impression he liked to project. He enjoyed telling me, and everyone else, that he didn't really know anything about computing and didn't understand why they'd put him on such an important team. He used to say that "contracting was the third biggest scam in Washington," after the income tax and Congress. He claimed he'd advised his boss that he'd be "next to useless" when they suggested moving him to the server team, but they moved him just the same. By his own account, all he'd done at work for the better part of the last decade was sit around and read books, though sometimes he'd also play games of solitaire—with a real deck of cards, not on the computer, of course—and reminisce about former wives ("she was a keeper") and girlfriends ("she took my car but it was worth it"). Sometimes he'd just pace all night and reload the Drudge Report.

When the phone rang to signal that something was broken, and bouncing a server didn't fix it, he'd just report it to the day shift. Essentially, his philosophy (if you could call it that) was that the night shift had to end sometime and the day shift had a deeper bench. Apparently, however, the day shift had gotten tired of coming in to work every morning to find Frank's feet up in front of the digital equivalent of a dumpster fire, and so I'd been hired.

For some reason, the agency had decided that it was preferable to bring me in than to let this old guy go. After a couple of weeks of working together, I was convinced that his continued employment had to be the result of some personal connection or favor. To test this hypothesis I tried to draw Frank out, and asked him which CIA directors or other agency brass he'd been with in the navy. But my question only provoked a tirade about how basically none of the navy vets high up at the agency had been enlisted men—they'd all been officers, which explained so much about the agency's dismal record. This lecture went on and